are vital to China's economy. "China," says Menon, "knows just how dependent it is on the US and they are not fools to be isolated and cut off from the global economy. They can't live without the US, without access to the US technology and its market."

A NEW WORLD DISORDER?

When Putin decided to invade Ukraine, part of his plan was to carve a new European order that "would recognise the important role and status of Russia as it had been completely marginalised by Europe", in Saran's words. Menon goes so far as to say that there is no world order in the first place. "Isn't it a fact that no European or American is willing to stand up and fight for Ukraine?" he asks. Saran too believes the pandemic exposed the lack of a world order as nations were unable to work together to meet a major security threat, ending up with vaccine nationalism rather than cooperation.

Tellis believes this may be overstating the case as the western liberal order is still dominant, with all its norms and institutions intact, albeit under some strain. For Menon, the aftermath of the Ukraine conflict will not be a make-or-break moment for the world. Reason: the world will have to deal with the second-order effects of a war that will see energy and commodity prices hit the roof and a much slower global economy. While there is likely to be a consolidation of the China-Russia axis, a distracted US will have shrinking bandwidth to deal with global problems. "The world is actually in a big mess," says Menon. "We are in transition between global orders. When it comes to the economy, we are multipolar, but with regard to military power, we are unipolar, with the US still the only country able to project its power globally."

If the China-Russia axis emerges stronger after the Ukraine crisis, some scholars predict the start of a new Cold War and even a new Iron Curtain. Yet others argue that it will be nothing like the Cold War that existed between the US and the erstwhile USSR, which had a strong military and ideological basis. Also, Europe had become the central geopolitical fault line of the world. But then its GDP fell from 30 per cent of global GDP in 1980 to around 16 per cent by 2016 and it stopped mattering—it no longer had the military clout or the economic power. Menon says that the world's biggest geopolitical fault lines have now shifted to Asia where there are many zones of conflict and nuclear powers jostling around.

Amidst all the flux, a new multipolar world is emerging—one that will perhaps be less stable and more dangerous. So, where does that leave India? Foreign minister S. Jaishankar perhaps has the answer—"India will have convergence with many nations but congruence with none." Raghavan talks of having a joint venture with Russia and the US rather than alliances. Saran believes that after Russia's invasion of Ukraine, "on balance, whether we like it or not, India will have to stand more towards the West. What other alternative do we have if our main adversary is China? India will still be looking for those who share our concerns about Chinese expansion and try to work together again."

India has hard choices to make, especially when it comes to the question of self-interest versus principles. In these turbulent times, experts concur that strategic autonomy should remain its lodestar. India needs to look out for itself first and safeguard its interests while balancing the extremes. Varma's advice: "We are entering an unknown new world. It is not a world of the brave but of the sensible." Both bravery and good sense may dictate that, sooner rather than later, India will have to get off the fence. ■



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"The NATO expansion threat is an excuse by Putin to recover whatever he can of the former Soviet Union"



SHIVSHANKAR MENON
Former National Security Advisor

"The US can't replace Russia for us. Will Americans give you a nuclear submarine on lease, as Russia did?"